RESEARCH RELATED PRINCIPLES FOR HELPING AD/HD CHILDREN IN THE CLASSROOM

RESEARCH FINDING: ***Having even one child with AD/HD in a classroom can present a major challenge even to experienced teachers. Possibly the most effective way of supporting the child is to support his teacher.***

Teaching Principle: Discuss the child's needs as a school issue, and adopt a whole-school approach to reinforcing agreed rules and providing positive encouragement. Never allow even an experienced teacher to feel 'marooned', and remember that teachers, as well as children, need acknowledgement of their problems, efforts and achievements.

RESEARCH FINDING: ***AD/HD children are "delay averse", i.e. they find waiting - even for a short space of time - intolerable. As a result they find it hard to wait in queues, turn-take in games / conversations, work towards long term rewards, raise their hand before speaking, take sufficient time to work carefully (hence the high error rate) etc.***

Teaching Principle: Try to minimise the amount of time an AD/HD child is kept waiting with nothing to do.

Examples:

- Encourage children to ask a "study buddy" for help.
- Ensure that behaviour modification is immediate.
- Make full use of computers as they provide immediate feedback.

RESEARCH FINDING: ***AD/HD children have difficulty inhibiting pre-potent responses - the opposite of a considered response. As a result, the children behave in an impulsive fashion, and this can lead to dangerous behaviour (running across a road), socially inept behaviour (saying what you think) and naughty behaviour (shouting out).***

Teaching Principle: Think of ways to encourage a "stop-think" approach and think ahead when planning (seating, classroom layout, trips etc.).

Examples:

- Build checking responses into work (e.g. check the arithmetic sign when the page is complete).
- Use visual prompts, e.g. a red line outside the door which means "STOP: think what to do when leaving or entering the room".
- Don't seat the child with AD/HD next to the fish tank, the computer etc.
- Have the child working with you and next to you for the school play etc.
- Take an extra helper on a trip and discuss basic rules with the class beforehand.

RESEARCH FINDING: ***AD/HD children often have working memory problems, and are likely to forget rules and instructions***

Teaching Principle: Keep rules and instructions as brief and simple as possible, and use a variety of memory aids.

Examples:

- Visual cues, e.g. a green traffic light when the class can talk quietly and red when the class should be silent.
- Check the child is holding instructions "on-line" while working
- Ask the child to rehearse instructions or provide them with a written version.
- Use cooker timers which make time "visible, audible and measurable" so that the child does not forget the amount of time available for a task.
- Go over the basic classroom rules each morning.

RESEARCH FINDING: *AD/HD children do not have problems with attention if the task is sufficiently interesting. If you can make the task the most exciting thing in the environment you have won! Lessons where the child sits and listens are likely to be when he seeks distractions - unless he is particularly interested in your subject, or you are an exceptionally gifted speaker.*

Teaching Principle: Try to make tasks as salient and interactive as possible.

Examples:

- Use imaginative computer software.
- Where a task is not salient but must be done (e.g. a page of arithmetic) break the page into smaller units - this gives the child a sense of completion and achievement which can itself become rewarding.
- Where possible adopt a multi-sensory or interactive teaching style.
- Give the child something to do while listening (e.g. 'playdoh' in story time, underlining main points or key words).
- Be aware that the child's fidgeting may be more disruptive to you than to children, but consider allowing the child permission to go outside for a run "x" number of times each day.
- Try alternating interesting with less interesting tasks.
- Build topics of work around the child's interests.
- Provide a quiet corner that is available to all children.
- Allow privileged access to the library .
- Experiment with headphones (experiment with soothing / stimulating music and white noise).
- Allow preferential seating (ask older children to experiment with seating positions and report back to you).

RESEARCH FINDING: *AD/HD children are often the subject of negative and angry comments. This leads to a downward spiral of events in which behaviour worsens and negative comments increase. Many AD/HD children feel they are failing on every front (social, academic and behavioural) and have extremely low self-esteem.*

Teaching Principle: You will make a greater impact on the child with positive than with negative comments, rewards rather than sanctions. Only tackle one or two problems at a time, and set realistic targets - in this way you increase the chance of success.

Examples:

- Look for "islands of strength" and make the most of them.
- Start the day with a public and positive comment about *something*.
- Pair the child with a responsible partner for a prestigious job such as delivering the register.
- Include positives in the home-school diary.
- Choose one problem, e.g. shouting out, and set a very realistic target and praise the child for success.
- Try to discuss problems in private, and ensure the child - and his classmates - know that you like him if not his behaviour.

RESEARCH FINDING: *AD/HD children are insatiable in their demands for attention.*

Teaching Principle: Give immediate and frequent attention for good behaviour and ignore (as far as possible) minor irritations such as fidgeting.

RESEARCH FINDING: *AD/HD children are poor at self-monitoring.*

Teaching Principle: Teach the child to be self-aware.

Examples:

- Tell the child when things are going well and how: e.g. "Well done Tom, you're working well today - you haven't once shouted out or talked to other people". The more times you tell the child exactly *why* you're pleased the more you will reinforce this behaviour.
- Ask the child to measure how long s/he is able to stay on-task, using a cooker timer, then praise and encourage him/her to try and beat this record.
- Encourage the child to know when s/he needs to work in a quiet corner / library / room, to take a run / breather outside or take time-out to calm down. The first stage of solving a problem is to be aware there is a problem.

RESEARCH FINDING: ***AD/HD children often have an external rather than internal locus of control, i.e. they feel that events are in charge of them rather than the opposite. This view leads to feelings of helplessness and "giving up" behaviour.***

Teaching Principle:

- Take every opportunity to ensure that the child attributes success to his/her own efforts.
- When the child tries and fails, treat this as a learning opportunity and try to ensure the child tries again and succeeds.
- Children taking medication need to be re-assured that it is them, and not medication, that leads to improvements - just as children who wear glasses are still responsible for learning to read.

RESEARCH FINDING: ***AD/HD children have problems with all aspects of organisation and behave least well in unstructured tasks and situations.***

Teaching Principle: Try to teach organisational skills and pre-empt problems.

Examples:

- Build in a high level of structure to lessons and the school day, and explain the structure to the child, so that he knows exactly what is going to happen and when.
- Anticipate and prepare for changes in structure, e.g. a supply teacher or trip.
- Be on hand to supervise the child at transitions from one setting to another.
- Consider ways of having a skilled teacher on duty at play and lunch times.
- Teach the class how to tidy a desk, how to use lists / organisers (point to 'glamorous' jobs that make use of these tools, e.g. pilots.

RESEARCH FINDING: ***Around 60% of AD/HD children are unpopular and unpopularity is highly predictive of a range of serious adult problems. Once a child is unpopular he is likely to remain so even if his behaviour improves. Both teachers and peers are biased in noticing negative behaviours more than positive behaviours, and their views are resistant to change. Peers are influenced by how the teacher acts towards the child with AD/HD: primary school children who are unpopular with the teacher are unpopular with the class. It is also the case that the whole class is likely to receive more negative behaviour from the teacher if there is one disruptive AD/HD member in the class, and peers are aware of this. Children who are aggressive, and/or who also have learning difficulties, are most at risk for peer-rejection. Once rejected, the children are deprived of the chance to practise and develop their social skills, and the problem worsens.***

Teaching Principle: One of the most significant ways you can help a child with AD/HD is to help him become accepted by his peers. The way to do this is to accept and like the child yourself, and this will probably be achieved when both you and the school acknowledge the child has a serious and *highly demanding* 'special need'. Seek advice from an Educational Psychologist if aggressive behaviour does not respond to interventions.

FORM 5.1

ADHD Intervention Checklist

Name _____ School Year _____ Grade _____

Begin Date	End Date		Degree of Success
		Environmental Interventions	
____	____	1. Assign student to classroom that is structured, consistent, and predictable.	_____
____	____	2. Seat student where most visual distractions are behind him or her (e.g., in front row with back to rest of class).[1]	_____
____	____	3. Seat student away from potential distractions (e.g., heaters, air conditioners, high traffic areas, pencil sharpeners, windows, water coolers, noisy classmates, etc.).	_____
____	____	4. Seat student near teacher as well as appropriate role models. Avoid isolating the student.	_____
____	____	5. Post a few simple rules in highly visible places in the classroom.	_____
____	____	6. Create a stimuli-reduced area that all students may use (e.g., study carrel in corner of room). Encourage student to self-select this environment when necessary.	_____
____	____	7. Permit student to stand, move between two desks, or sit at a round table and move from chair to chair while working.	_____
____	____	8. Provide brief breaks (e.g., to run errands, water plants, distribute materials) or exercise breaks to relieve the "wiggles."[2]	_____
____	____	9. Permit student to use earplugs or headphones to block auditory distractions during tests or independent seat work.	_____
____	____	10. Allow for a higher level of restlessness and movement on the part of the student during teacher presentation than would normally be acceptable.[3]	_____
____	____	11. Other _____	_____
____	____	12. Other _____	_____
____	____	13. Other _____	_____

Begin Date	End Date		Degree of Success

Academic Interventions

____	____	14. Experiment with a variety of testing formats to find the one best suited to the student's learning style (e.g., true-false, fill-in, multiple choice, or oral).	____
____	____	15. Provide lined answer spaces for responses on short answer or essay tests.	____
____	____	16. Permit student to take tests in less distracting environment (e.g., resource room, study carrel).	____
____	____	17. Permit short breaks during tests.	____
____	____	18. Teach student test-taking strategies (e.g., eliminating all incorrect responses on a multiple-choice test rather than rushing to choose a correct answer).[4]	____
____	____	19. Give student as much time as needed to complete a test. Avoid timed tests whenever possible.	____
____	____	20. Provide student with cloze notes to use during lesson presentations. The cloze technique provides student with an outline or set of notes with key words missing. The student is expected to fill in missing key words during direct instruction.	____
____	____	21. Provide photocopied text or outline that student can underline or highlight key concepts during direct instruction.	____
____	____	22. Provide ample "wait time" (i.e., the amount of time you wait for an answer during classroom discussions). Allow at least 5 seconds. Return to student if he or she needs more time to organize a verbal response.	____
____	____	23. Show student examples of completed assignments that demonstrate the teacher's expectations (e.g., research projects, book reports, essays, dioramas, or stories).	____
____	____	24. Provide student with audiotape of important text material.	____
____	____	25. Permit student to highlight main ideas in textbooks and jot notes in margins.	____
____	____	26. Encourage the use of a word processor for preparation of assignments.	____
____	____	27. Permit alternate methods for mortaring (e.g., photocopy the notes of a more organized student, permit the student to compare his or her notes with those of another student, or allow student to copy the notes of the teacher).	____
____	____	28. Schedule more demanding classes or subjects when student is at peak performance.	____

Begin Date	End Date		Degree of Success
____	____	29. Emphasize quality of assignment rather than quantity (e.g., three well-constructed sentences are preferable to not handing in the assignment at all).	____
____	____	30. Make eye contact with student before giving instructions. Ask student to restate instructions before beginning independent practice.	____
____	____	31. Teach, model, and frequently reinforce one specific previewing or comprehension strategy and encourage the student to practice and use it consistently (e.g., SQ3R).[5]	____
____	____	32. Give a concrete reinforcement, such as a star or token, for the completion of each in-class assignment.	____
____	____	33. Enlist the help of an aide or volunteer to read important material aloud to the student.	____
____	____	34. Allow the student to dictate thoughts and ideas to someone else before copying his or her dictated information.	____
____	____	35. Give student several options for both obtaining and reporting information (e.g., audio- or videotapes, interviews, reading, experiences, projects, displays, oral presentations, photographic essays, conference with teacher, field trips, etc.).	____
____	____	36. Permit the use of calculator to check accuracy of math computation.	____
____	____	37. Other _____	____
____	____	38. Other _____	____
____	____	39. Other _____	____

Instructional Interventions

____	____	40. Vary lesson presentations between those requiring student to sit still and listen with those that are more visual or participatory.	____
____	____	41. Modify curriculum (e.g., choose an easier reading level or require fewer or easier spelling words).	____
____	____	42. Use an interactive teaching approach that introduces the same information to the student through each of the senses.	____

Begin Date	End Date		Degree of Success
____	____	43. Use strategies that cue student as to the expected learning outcomes (e.g., maps, charts, outlines, preview questions, study guides, or vocabulary lists to focus student's attention on key information).	____
____	____	44. Devote some instructional time each day to the teaching or reviewing (or both) of memory, reading, organizational, or behavioral strategies.	____
____	____	45. Structure lessons in a logical and sequential fashion. Minimize instructional "bird walks," which lose or confuse the student.	____
____	____	46. Keep directions brief, logical, and sequential.	____
____	____	47. Summarize key information more frequently and check for understanding by asking student(s) to respond physically (e.g., thumbs up, thumbs down).	____
____	____	48. Provide periodic breaks in longer lesson presentations.	____
____	____	49. Use the overhead projector to focus student's attention (e.g., frame important information, reveal a step-by-step process, use different colors and shapes, or involve the student in writing on the transparency).	____
____	____	50. Give student verbal and visual clues in anticipation of introducing important information or key concepts.	____
____	____	51. Use computer-based drills and instruction to provide practice and to reinforce basic skills.	____
____	____	52. Use proximity to the student during a lesson presentation to increase interaction and to hold his or her attention.[6]	____
____	____	53. Develop private signals with student to focus his or her attention (e.g., wink, point to ears or eyes, touch top of head).	____
____	____	54. Use the unison response method for increased student attention and participation (e.g., individual chalkboards or magic slates, or yes-no class responses, such as thumbs up or down or open hand, closed hand).	____
____	____	55. Make frequent direct eye contact to gain and hold student's attention during lesson presentation.	____
____	____	56. Present more difficult subjects or tasks to the student when performance is at peak (e.g., first thing in the morning, 2 hours after medication has been given).	____
____	____	57. Teach memory strategies, such as mnemonics, frequent written or spoken repetitions, visualization, or oral rehearsal.	____

Begin Date	End Date		Degree of Success
____	____	58. Use the "turn to your partner" technique during the lesson presentation to help the student summarize what he or she has learned or to refocus attention.	____
____	____	59. Teach student specific information-locating strategies (e.g., how to use textbooks, reference books, skimming and scanning, and card catalog).	____
____	____	60. Develop a classroom or subject matter reference book that contains frequently used vocabulary or spelling words, rules, procedures, checklists, and mathematical formulas.	____
____	____	61. Keep a folder containing the student's best work as a comparative standard against which to evaluate future performance.	____
____	____	62. Evaluate all instructional handouts to make sure they are well-designed and clearly written. Avoid any material that is poorly photocopied, handwritten, or in tiny type.	____
____	____	63. Develop specific and consistent classroom routines to facilitate learning and organization (e.g., how to get help when student has questions, where to turn in completed assignments, what to do when free time is available, etc.).	____
____	____	64. Make sure student comprehends task before permitting him or her to begin independent work (e.g., repeat the directions to the teacher or another student, write down the steps, or highlight the directions on a handout as they are read aloud).	____
____	____	65. Teach mathematical processes using manipulatives and real-world examples.	____
____	____	66. Visually display commonly used mathematical formulas. Show examples in a step-by-step format or develop a checklist.	____
____	____	67. Use daily oral activities (e.g., one math problem-solving activity; one language activity, one memory technique per day) to reinforce skills.	____
____	____	68. Visually display the most commonly used problem-solving strategies in mathematics.[7]	____
____	____	69. Use graph paper for math computation to keep numbers in columns.	____
____	____	70. When working story problems, have the student underline key words and phrases.	____
____	____	71. Other _____	____
		_____	
____	____	72. Other _____	____
		_____	

Begin Date	End Date		Degree of Success
____	____	73. Other _____	____

Organizational Interventions

____	____	74. List all special classroom events for the week or month on a large calendar and periodically refer to them to assist student with long-term planning.	____
____	____	75. Give student a few minutes at the end of each subject or class to organize books, papers, and so on, before beginning next instructional sequence.	____
____	____	76. Give student extra set of books to increase the likelihood that texts will always be available when needed. Keep one at school and one at home.	____
____	____	77. Use color-coded materials to help student keep organized (e.g., folders, sticky notes, xeroxing on different colors of paper).	____
____	____	78. Require that the student have individual notebook or folders for each subject. Help the student index them.	____
____	____	79. Notify parent(s) immediately of missing or incomplete assignments.	____
____	____	80. Develop a reward-and-consequence system for both in-school work as well as homework completion.	____
____	____	81. Assist student to develop a system to keep track of completed, partially completed, and corrected work (e.g., folders, notebook, baskets, etc.).	____
____	____	82. Provide frequent reminders (both written and verbal) of due dates for assignments.	____
____	____	83. Divide lengthy, long-range assignments into steps, and provide intermediate deadlines for the completion of each step.	____
____	____	84. Develop checklists for common classroom assignments (e.g., writing a book report, composing an essay, doing a long-division problem). Tape these lists to the desk or keep them in a notebook where they are easily accessible.	____
____	____	85. Develop checklists for common classroom procedures (e.g., arriving at school, getting ready to go home).	____
____	____	86. Establish, display, and maintain a daily classroom routine and schedule. Explain changes to the schedule well in advance.	____
____	____	87. Monitor clutter on the student's desk. Make sure the desktop is free from all material except that on which he or she is working.	____

Begin Date	End Date		Degree of Success
____	____	88. Have the student clean out and reorganize his or her desk or locker at regular intervals. Ask the student to purchase a desk or locker organizer to assist.	_____
____	____	89. Check notebooks and folders weekly to make sure completed work has been turned in and graded assignments have been taken home.	_____
____	____	90. Write all assignments for the day on a chalkboard or flip chart. Use color, graphics, and humor to keep this area interesting.	_____
____	____	91. Provide a time at the end of each day for the student to reorganize his or her desk and homework materials. Designate a "coach" or "buddy" to help with this organizational checkpoint.	_____
____	____	92. Have student cross items off a list when completed to promote a sense of accomplishment.	_____
____	____	93. Systematically teach organizational skills to student, focusing on the skills before the subject matter.[8]	_____
____	____	94. Teach student to monitor and record his or her own work productivity and behavior.	_____
____	____	95. Other _____	_____
____	____	96. Other _____	_____
____	____	97. Other _____	_____

Homework Interventions

____	____	98. Go over assignments that will be going home using both auditory and visual presentations whenever possible (e.g., chalkboard, overhead, or handouts).	_____
____	____	99. Ask student to restate homework expectations or read them aloud from his or her assignment notebook before leaving classroom.	_____
____	____	100. Allow extra time for student to copy assignments.	_____
____	____	101. Develop a homework buddy system in which the buddies monitor each other to make sure the assignments are understood and all necessary materials are taken home. Encourage buddies to exchange telephone numbers.	_____

Begin Date	End Date		Degree of Success
_____	_____	102. Require the regular use of an assignment notebook. Include columns for assignment, date due, and date handed in. Inspect and initial each day. As student learns routine and becomes more consistent, sign once per week.	_____
_____	_____	103. Require periodic status reports on long-term assignments.	_____
_____	_____	104. Provide a step-by-step sequence of intermediate steps when giving the student a complex assignment.	_____
_____	_____	105. Frequently review and reinforce successful homework strategies in cooperative groups.[9]	_____
_____	_____	106. Monitor the writing down of homework assignments.	_____
_____	_____	107. Send daily or weekly progress reports home.	_____
_____	_____	108. Eliminate all "busywork" homework assignments; include only material that is absolutely necessary to practice or learn.	_____
_____	_____	109. Use highlighter markers or "neon" sticky tabs to indicate to the student where to start or stop an assignment or where important information can be found.	_____
_____	_____	110. Reduce the amount of homework initially to achieve small increments of success, and then gradually increase expectations as confidence increases.	_____
_____	_____	111. Permit the student to submit work as soon as it is completed.	_____
_____	_____	112. Give feedback on all completed homework assignments.	_____
_____	_____	113. Have frequent, even if short, one-to-one homework conferences with student to assess completion rate, quality of work, and problems he or she may be having.	_____
_____	_____	114. Assign a peer to help the student with homework.	_____
_____	_____	115. Allow the student additional time to turn in homework assignments.	_____
_____	_____	116. Send homework assignments and materials home with someone other than the student (e.g., sibling or neighbor).	_____
_____	_____	117. Provide ample guided practice for the student prior to giving homework assignment(s).	_____
_____	_____	118. Other _____	_____
_____	_____	119. Other _____	_____

Begin Date	End Date		Degree of Success
_____	_____	120. Other _____	_____

Behavioral Interventions

_____	_____	121. Design an individual behavior management plan suited to the student's unique needs.[10]	_____
_____	_____	122. Use a timer to help student stay on task. He or she can be rewarded when he or she beats the timer.	_____
_____	_____	123. Structure positive ways student can receive attention from teacher (e.g., classroom or leadership responsibilities).	_____
_____	_____	124. Establish a secret signal to remind the student to return to task. Praise the student when he or she is on task.	_____
_____	_____	125. Implement a cognitive behavioral modification or therapy program to encourage a self-monitoring approach on the part of the student.[11]	_____
_____	_____	126. Have student chart his or her own instances of appropriate or inappropriate target behavior (e.g., hand raising, on-target conversation or interruptions, swearing).[12]	_____
_____	_____	127. Give the student choices when possible (e.g., to decide whether to work on math or reading assignment).	_____
_____	_____	128. Give specific praise for desired behavior, taking care to give more praise than reprimands.	_____
_____	_____	129. Keep reprimands brief and directed at unwanted behavior rather than at the student.	_____
_____	_____	130. Develop classroom rules with student discussion and input.	_____
_____	_____	131. Teach classroom rules as if they were subject matter. Role-play examples of excellent behavior. Give student(s) opportunities for practice. Test knowledge of rules. Review rules regularly.	_____
_____	_____	132. Set hourly, daily, weekly, or monthly goals with the student, and provide frequent feedback on the student's progress.	_____
_____	_____	133. Develop a hierarchy of consequences.[13]	_____
_____	_____	134. Teach "stop, listen, think, say, do" strategy to reduce impulsivity.	_____

Begin Date	End Date		Degree of Success

Social Skills Interventions

_____	_____	135. Use positive practice to reinforce desired skills.	_____
_____	_____	136. Praise appropriate social behavior more frequently than reprimanding inappropriate behavior. Tally the incidence of each.	_____
_____	_____	137. Set up social behavior goals with student, and implement a reward program.	_____
_____	_____	138. Prompt appropriate social behavior either verbally or with a private signal.	_____
_____	_____	139. Teach prerequisite skills for cooperative learning (listening, accepting feedback, praising, giving feedback), and use this technique in classroom when appropriate.[14]	_____
_____	_____	140. Implement a social skills program either with the individual student or with the entire class.[15]	_____
_____	_____	141. Reinforce social skills training in natural settings (e.g., playground, lunchroom).	_____
_____	_____	142. Assign special responsibilities to student in presence of peer group so others observe the student in a positive light.	_____
_____	_____	143. Use group rewards as an incentive (e.g., use "hero" technique in which one student earns a reward for the entire class).	_____
_____	_____	144. Change reinforcers frequently to maintain interest and motivation. Consult with student regarding choice of reinforcers.	_____
_____	_____	145. Other _____	_____
_____	_____	146. Other _____	_____
_____	_____	147. Other _____	_____